DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Does God Watch Every Creature?

Derech Hashem 2:1:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Review of Part 1; Part 2, Chapter 1, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

This short recording opens Part 2 of the book, after the Pesah break. The transcript is unclear in places; these notes follow what can be understood.

Part 2: hashgahah

Part 2 of Derech Hashem is about hashgahah, divine providence. We hear the terms hashgahah peratit and hashgahah kelalit often; this section explains what they mean. Before beginning, the Rabbi reviewed Part 1, a quarter of the book, since there had been no chance to go over it during Pesah.

Review of Part 1

- **Chapter 1** set out the principles of what Hashem is.
- **Chapter 2** explained the purpose of creation: Hashem wants to bestow goodness on His creatures. The greatest good is Hashem Himself, and since He cannot duplicate Himself, the only way is for us to connect to Him. We must work to receive that closeness, so that it is truly ours and not a gift handed to us on a plate.
- **Chapter 3** developed this: there must be good and bad in the world, a pull to each, and we turn ourselves towards the good. It also described the world before and after the sin of Adam. Because of the sin we must go through death and decomposition and come back to life. The view of the vast majority of commentators is that the World to Come will be body and soul together, with a refined body, not the tired, lethargic, lustful body we have today. The body took part in the work, so it must share in the reward. Until then, after death, the soul alone enjoys a taste of what is to come.
- **Chapter 4** explained that since we live in a material world with material bodies, the default is to fall: "if you don't work on yourself at all, you will fall." That is why we must constantly learn musar and remind ourselves of our duties. Hashem created a system in which engaging with the physical world correctly elevates it, and the chapter spoke of Torah and of the fear and love of Hashem. Good comes from the illumination of Hashem's face, as the kohen blesses, "May Hashem make His face shine upon you"; bad comes when we step out of the beam, the hiding of His face.

- **Chapter 5** taught that every physical thing has a koah, a force above it that allows it to exist. It is not Hashem directly, which would be too intense, but a chain of forces coming down from Him. The Rabbi said this chapter is essentially the basics of Kabbalah and the Sefirot. Our existence flows downward from those forces, but our choices have an effect upward, which then comes around again, like a cycle.

A participant asked whether everything is called into being in this way. The Rabbi said yes, one hundred percent: matter exists only because Hashem wills it, as taught in the first chapter. He recalled his early analogy: imagine creating a whole universe in your mind for twenty minutes; the moment a phone call distracts you, it vanishes. If Hashem were not constantly involved, nothing would exist.

A digression on Birkat Kohanim

A participant raised Birkat Kohanim as a daily connection to Hashem commanded by the Torah itself. The Rabbi explained its structure: three verses of three, five and seven words, fifteen in all, ascending in level. The first is material blessing: "May Hashem bless you" with wealth, as Rashi says, "and guard you," since wealth can be lost. The second is spiritual blessing, and the third is peace. A person can have the greatest material success and still not be blessed.

He added a number idea. The material world is built on seven: seven days, seven notes in music, and so on. Eight is always just above nature, which is why brit milah is on the eighth day and overrides Shabbat: Shabbat, the seventh, celebrates holiness within nature, while brit milah transcends it. The word kohen has the numerical value 75, and the Maharal says the kohen is the bridge between nature and the spiritual, between seventy and eighty.

Paragraph 1: everything exists for humanity

Part 2, Chapter 1 opens with a general statement about providence, built as always on what came before. All of creation, whether celestial or earthly, exists only because it has some role in the ultimate goal, which is humanity's connection to Hashem. Everything is governed according to that purpose.

The Rabbi explained the idea "outside" before reading it. A spider creeping across the floor has no individual role. The spider species as a whole has a role to play, and every creature has its use, "even rats." But Hashem does not attend to this particular rat; He ensures there are, say, a million rats in England, because that is what creation needs. If one is run over, that is chance.

The company fleet. A business needs twenty cars to run. The owner does not invest personal attention in each car; if one crashes, it is replaced. What matters is that twenty working cars exist. Your own personal car is different: you clean it, you care for it. In the same way, the purpose of existence is humanity, and on human beings there is generally specific providence, hashgahah peratit. Everything else has general providence, hashgahah kelalit, on the species but not on the details. (The Rabbi noted that some human beings act like animals and are relegated to the level of animals, a point the book will discuss.)

The safari. Hashem wants the safari to exist (perhaps so we appreciate the beauty of His world; we cannot really answer why). For that there must be lions and zebras, perhaps a thousand of

each. Which lion dies of disease, or which sheep a lion devours, is not attended to individually. What matters is that there are enough.

Extinction

A participant asked: when a whole species is near extinction, is that against Hashem's plan? The Rabbi answered that we do not know Hashem's plan. The dodo and the dinosaurs had a purpose in their time; perhaps that purpose is now finished, or they remain for historical purposes. But that does not let us stand by: "You have your duty to look after the world... every creature we have a duty to look after." If a species does go extinct despite our efforts, that does not mean it went against Hashem. Hashem does not intervene in little things, but He does in the general picture.

Summary

- Part 2 of Derech Hashem is about hashgahah, divine providence.
- Part 1 taught who Hashem is, why He created the world, the body and soul, the effect of the sin of Adam, and the chain of forces through which He sustains everything.
- Everything in creation exists only to serve humanity's purpose of connecting to Hashem.
- Non-human creatures receive general providence over their species; humans receive individual providence.
- We still have a duty to protect every species, even though Hashem's providence over them is general.

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